

Happy thanksgiving, dear natives

For sometime there's been a popular idea being bandied about which suggests people born on the right side of 1980 are more adept at understanding and developing technology. The idea was originally proposed in 2001 by educationist Mark Prensky in a paper titled Digital Natives, Digital Immigrants wherein he suggested young people are "native speakers" of the digital language of computers, videogames and the Internet. In contrast, those who were not born into the digital world but have, at some later point in their lives, become fascinated by and adopted many or most aspects of the new technology are, and always will be, Digital Immigrants. Since the idea has been proposed, almost every corporate presentation I've ever been coerced into attending has pushed forward this belief, while strictly segmenting their target audiences based on it.

While I agree to a certain extent that there's a divide, I'm not entirely sure about buying into the concept fully. I belong to the group Prensky would call natives or what other jargon enthusiasts would call millennials. Even in my short lifetime and within this restrictive grouping I've been labelled under, I see instances of discontinuity: interns (born in the 90s) not knowing what a dial tone is, not knowing how to ninja-call using Android's nine-key dialling feature, not knowing what a mixed tape is and so many other ways in which they seem "different". In fact this divide has led to some interesting products being launched of late such as Milktape – a USB cassette tape that is trying to revive the once cutting-edge romantic practice of making mixed tapes for significant others. It's also led to quite a few "Odes to Winamp" last month, but I digress.

The point is, do digital natives have an innate, otherworldly sense of anything computer or microchip-based? The assumption that someone below a certain age automatically attains a certain level of technological expertise just doesn't seem right. Sure, we've all seen videos of babies swishing and tapping their way around iPads (and felt the chills) but are all of those babies going to actually build such technologies? What people fail to realise is that the very set of protocols that the internet is built on was created by people who'd technically be labelled Digital Immigrants. Sure, I can't imagine Tim Berners-Lee going YOLO

on Whatsapp, but I'm sure he'd be comfortable with "modern" technology and sure as hell he'd be able to build a Whatsapp if he wanted to.

No one is inherently fluent in "digital" in exactly the same way no one is inherently fluent with any language at birth. Let's not confuse comfort with proficiency here. In fact, if anything, I feel the current crop of digital natives severely lack imagination with all the constant bombardment of digital media around them all through their childhoods. This is why it was not just refreshing but exhilarating to meet 15 year olds like Angad and Karan, who are trying to fix this very problem through their easily accessible 3D-printers. Be sure to read more about them in the cover story – they are truly inspirational.

And it's not just these young'uns but digital immigrants such as IAS officer Rajesh Aggarwal and Myshkin Ingawale (PhD in Wikipedia) who are also trying to solve some of the most critical problems plaguing our country. And they're all doing it using technology. Mr. Aggarwal is spearheading a seachange in the way in which ordinary citizens interface with the government by revamping the country's e-governance infrastructure and Myshkin is trying to disrupt medicare in India by trying to make reliable diagnostics accessible and affordable for one and all.

All of this proves to a certain degree that simple access to something, in this case technology, doesn't necessarily translate to understanding. It's like saying someone who has grown up reading books will be able to write one someday. Possible, but not a certainty. So remember, whether you're a digital native or immigrant, imagination and a desire to build something is all you need to effect a change. If you have any ideas like the ones in our cover story this month, we'd like to hear from you. Here's wishing you season's greetings and a happy new year! 🍷



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"No one is inherently fluent in "digital" in exactly the same way no one is inherently fluent with any language at birth."

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth'.

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
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